BEHAVIOURAL PROBLEMS OF EMPLOYEES IN ORGANISATIONS

BMS– Organisational Behaviour

Understanding employee behaviour, causes and managerial responses

DEFINITION: EMPLOYEE BEHAVIOURAL PROBLEMS

Employee behavioural problems: Recurring or significant patterns of employee behaviour that negatively affect individual performance, relationships, team functioning, or organisational effectiveness.

OB perspective: Organisational Behaviour examines the causes, consequences and management of such behaviour at the individual, group and organisational levels.

Important distinction: A behavioural problem is the observable behaviour; the underlying cause may involve personality, perception, attitude, motivation, emotions, leadership, group dynamics, organisational culture or structure.

Managerial principle: Diagnose the behaviour and its causes before deciding on corrective action.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Identify common behavioural problems in organisations

Distinguish individual, group and organisational behavioural problems

Connect behavioural problems with core OB concepts

Diagnose behaviour rather than simply label employees

Suggest appropriate managerial interventions

WHAT IS AN EMPLOYEE BEHAVIOURAL PROBLEM?

A pattern of employee behaviour that negatively affects individual, team or organisational effectiveness

The same behaviour may have different underlying causes

OB focuses on understanding why behaviour occurs and how it can be managed

Managerial diagnosis should consider both employee and organisational factors

INDIVIDUAL-LEVEL BEHAVIOURAL PROBLEMS

Low motivation and low work effort

Negative attitudes and cynicism

Absenteeism and lateness

Poor adaptability to change

Lack of initiative

Emotional outbursts or poor emotional regulation

Low job involvement or commitment

Definition: Behavioural difficulties primarily expressed by an individual employee that can reduce personal effectiveness or work adjustment.

GROUP-LEVEL BEHAVIOURAL PROBLEMS

Interpersonal conflict

Poor teamwork and cooperation

Workplace incivility

Gossip and rumours

Knowledge hoarding

Group conformity and reluctance to disagree

Blame shifting among team members

Definition: Behavioural difficulties arising in interactions among employees that affect relationships, cooperation or team performance.

ORGANISATION-LEVEL BEHAVIOURAL PROBLEMS

Resistance to organisational change

Office politics and favouritism

Employee silence

Unethical behaviour

Counterproductive work behaviour

High employee turnover

Weak organisational citizenship

Definition: Behavioural patterns shaped by or affecting the wider organisational system, culture, structure or practices.

BEHAVIOURAL PROBLEM → OB CONCEPT

Low motivation → Motivation theories, rewards, goals

Conflict → Personality, communication, group dynamics

Resistance to change → Perception, attitudes, change management

Incivility → Emotions, attitudes, social interaction

Employee silence → Power, leadership, culture, psychological safety

Office politics → Power, influence and organisational politics

20 COMMON BEHAVIOURAL PROBLEMS

1. Absenteeism 2. Turnover 3. Low motivation 4. Poor performance

5. Resistance to change 6. Conflict 7. Incivility 8. Poor teamwork

9. Negative attitude 10. Employee silence 11. Office politics

12. Counterproductive behaviour 13. Unethical behaviour 14. Poor communication

15. Emotional outbursts 16. Bullying 17. Lack of initiative

18. Blame shifting 19. Knowledge hoarding 20. Gossip and rumours

IS THE EMPLOYEE REALLY 'LAZY'?

A highly experienced employee has become less productive.

He frequently arrives late and avoids team meetings.

He refuses to use a new digital system.

He complains about management and has stopped helping colleagues.

The manager concludes: 'He has become lazy.'

Question: What alternative explanations should an OB manager investigate?

DIAGNOSING THE CASE THROUGH OB

Personality: Has the employee always behaved this way?

Perception: How does the employee perceive the change?

Attitude: Has job satisfaction or trust declined?

Motivation: Are rewards and goals still meaningful?

Emotions: Is frustration affecting behaviour?

Group: Has the employee's relationship with colleagues changed?

Leadership: How is the manager interacting with the employee?

Culture: Does the organisation support learning and change?

A MANAGERIAL DIAGNOSIS FRAMEWORK

STEP 1 – OBSERVE: What exactly is the behaviour?

STEP 2 – IDENTIFY: Is it individual, group or organisational?

STEP 3 – DIAGNOSE: What factors may be causing it?

STEP 4 – INTERVENE: What can the manager realistically change?

STEP 5 – FOLLOW UP: Has the behaviour improved?

POSSIBLE CAUSES OF BEHAVIOURAL PROBLEMS

Individual: Personality, ability, perception, emotions, attitudes

Job: Workload, role ambiguity, lack of autonomy, poor job design

Leadership: Poor communication, unfair treatment, lack of support

Group: Conflict, norms, exclusion, lack of trust

Organisation: Culture, structure, rewards, policies and politics

External: Family, economic or environmental pressures

MANAGERIAL RESPONSES

Clarify expectations and roles

Provide feedback and coaching

Review workload and job design

Improve communication and participation

Strengthen recognition and reward systems

Address conflict early

Create safe channels for employee voice

Build a respectful and ethical organisational culture

CLASSROOM ACTIVITY: BEHAVIOUR DETECTIVE

Form small groups

Give each group one behavioural problem

Identify: What is the behaviour?

Identify: What could be causing it?

Apply at least three OB concepts

Recommend two managerial interventions

Present your diagnosis in 3 minutes

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

Is employee behaviour mainly caused by personality or the work environment?

Can a good employee develop problematic behaviour because of poor management?

When should a manager treat behaviour as a performance issue?

How can organisational culture reinforce undesirable behaviour?

Why is labelling an employee 'lazy' often an inadequate diagnosis?

KEY TAKEAWAY

Do not ask only: 'What is wrong with the employee?'

Ask: 'What is producing this behaviour?'

Effective OB diagnosis considers:

Individual + Job + Group + Leadership + Culture + Organisational System

Behavioural management begins with diagnosis, not blame.

REFLECTION

Think of one behavioural problem you have observed HERE.

What was the visible behaviour?

What might have been the underlying cause?

Which OB concept best explains it?

What would you do differently as a manager?